

VEER

Is This Safe?

Privacy, trust, and knowing when to double-check.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Tell which of your worries are real and which ones aren't worth the energy.

Know what it can and can't see of your life, and what changes that.

Spot when it's likely to be wrong — and check it in about five seconds.

Keep a short list of things that should never go into it.

Recognise the new scams that use this technology, including the one aimed at parents and grandparents.

Use it with confidence instead of vague unease.

This is the cautious reader's guide. Being careful about a new technology is sensible, not backward — and nearly every worry has a specific, practical answer.

01

The three things people worry about

Almost everyone arrives with the same three worries, usually unspoken. Naming them makes them much easier to deal with.

"Is it taking my information?" The privacy worry. What happens to what I type, who can read it, is it being sold.

"Is it lying to me?" The trust worry. It sounds so certain. How would I know if it were wrong?

"Is it going to replace me?" The bigger worry underneath, and the one this book can't fully answer.

Here's the honest ranking, and it isn't the one most people expect.

The trust worry deserves the most attention. Being confidently misled is the failure that will actually cost you something, and it's the one you can do most about. Five of the nine lessons here are about it.

The privacy worry is real but manageable. It comes down to a short list of things not to type and knowing what it can see. Two lessons, and then you're done thinking about it.

The replacement worry is outside this book. One honest sentence: this is a tool that drafts and explains, it works from what you give it, and the people getting value from it are directing it rather than being displaced by it. That won't settle the question, and it isn't meant to.

Try this now. Decide which of the three is actually yours. Read that lesson first.

02

What it can and can't see

This is the question behind most of the unease, and the answer is more reassuring than people expect.

Claude cannot see your life. Not your email. Not your files. Not your photos. Not what else is open on your computer, what you searched for yesterday, where you are, or who you called. None of it.

It has no window into your machine at all. What it has is the message you type.

What it can see is a short list:

What you type into the box.

What you deliberately attach — a document, a photo, a screenshot.

What was said earlier in that same conversation.

That's it. Nothing arrives by itself.

THE ONE THING THAT CHANGES THIS

There's a feature called a connector that links Claude to an app you already use — your email, your calendar, your files. It only ever works if you set it up and approve it yourself, deliberately, and you can undo it. Nothing connects quietly in the background. Until you do that, the list above is the whole picture.

Try this now. Open a fresh conversation and ask it something about your own calendar. Watch it tell you it has no idea. That's the correct answer, and it's worth seeing once.

03

What happens to what you type

This is the question people most want a single clean answer to. This guide is not going to print one, and the reason matters.

What a company does with your conversations depends on which plan you're on, which settings you've chosen, and what region you're in — and it changes. Any specific answer printed here would be out of date before the ink dried, and a confident wrong answer about your privacy is worse than no answer.

So here is something more useful: the four questions worth knowing the answer to, and where to find them.

Is what I type used to improve the system? Look for a data or privacy setting in your account, and check whether it's on by default. This is usually the setting people most want to change.

Can a person read my conversations? The policy will say under what circumstances — usually safety review or a support request you started.

Can I delete things? Look for how to delete a single conversation and how to delete your whole account. Confirm what deletion actually removes.

Is it different on a paid or work plan? Often yes. Business and personal plans frequently have different terms.

All four live in the same two places: the **privacy or data settings** inside your account, and the **privacy policy** on the company's site. Fifteen minutes, once.

THE RULE THAT WORKS NO MATTER WHAT THE POLICY SAYS

Don't type anything you'd genuinely mind being read by a stranger. Not because someone is reading — but because it's a rule that survives policy changes, new features, company sales, and the small chance that you misremembered a setting.

Applied to real life: a rough draft of a difficult email is fine. A confusing letter with your address on it is a judgement call — you could remove the address first. Your medical history in full, or a document belonging to your employer, deserves a pause.

Try this now. Open your account settings and find the privacy or data section. Don't change anything yet. Learn where it is.

04

Four things to never type in

Short list. Worth memorising.

Passwords, PINs, and login details. For anything, ever. There is no task that requires it.

Full card, bank, or account numbers.

Government identification numbers. Social security, national insurance, passport, driving licence.

Other people's private details they haven't agreed to share — someone else's medical situation, financial position, or address.

The useful part isn't the list. It's knowing what to do when you need help with something that contains one of these.

Describe instead of pasting. *I've had a letter about a missed card payment and I don't understand what it's asking me to do* gets you the same help as pasting the letter, with none of the numbers.

Black out before you attach. If you're sharing a photo of a document, cover the account number and address first. A finger over the number works.

Change the names. *My friend has a situation with her landlord* works exactly as well as using her name.

IF YOU'VE ALREADY TYPED ONE OF THESE

Don't panic, and don't ignore it either. Delete that conversation. If it was a password, change that password — the same advice as typing it into any wrong box. Then carry on.

Try this now. Take a real document you'd like help with and write the describe-instead-of-paste version.

05

Why it sometimes makes things up

This is the most important lesson in the book.

Claude can be confidently, completely wrong. Not garbled, not obviously broken — wrong in the same calm, fluent, well-organised voice it uses when it's right.

A made-up statistic reads exactly like a real one. An invented detail about a law, a product, or a person arrives with the same steady confidence as a fact. **There is no tone of voice to listen for.** That's the whole problem, and it's why "it sounded sure" is worth nothing.

Why it happens, in plain terms: it produces language that fits, rather than looking something up. Most of the time what fits is also true, because it has read an enormous amount. But when it doesn't know, it doesn't go quiet. It produces something that *sounds* like the right kind of answer.

Where it's most likely to happen — this is the genuinely useful part:

Specific numbers, dates, and prices. Especially precise-sounding ones.

Names of people, books, studies, or laws. Including ones that sound completely plausible.

Anything very recent. It doesn't automatically know what happened last week.

Anything small and local. Your town's council rules, a small business's opening hours.

Anything you pushed it to produce after it hedged. Pressure produces confident answers, not correct ones.

06

How to catch it

You don't need to check everything. That would be exhausting and you'd stop. You need to know which things to check, and three questions sort it in about five seconds.

Could I check this in one search? Names, dates, numbers, prices, rules, addresses. If it's checkable in ten seconds, check it.

Does it matter if it's wrong? A dinner suggestion, no. Anything you're about to send, sign, pay, or act on, yes.

Would I want a person to confirm this? If the honest answer is yes, that's your answer.

Two moves that do most of the work:

ASK IT TO MARK ITS OWN UNCERTAINTY

Before I rely on any of that — which parts are you confident about, and which parts should I check myself?

It will often flag its own shakiest claims. That isn't a guarantee, and it can be wrong about being wrong. But it's free and it works more often than you'd expect.

ASK IT TO ARGUE THE OTHER SIDE

What's the strongest case against what you just told me?

Useful when the answer is a judgement rather than a fact. If the counter-argument is stronger than the original, you've learned something.

Try this now. Ask it about something you already know well. Watch where it's excellent and where it drifts. That calibrates you better than any reassurance.

07

The four you always confirm with a person

NO EXCEPTIONS

Money. Legal matters. Health. And anything you can't undo.

This is not a reason to avoid using it in those areas. Claude is genuinely useful in every one of them — as long as you're clear about which job it's doing.

What it's good for in those four areas: understanding what a letter or a diagnosis actually means. Working out what questions to ask. Preparing for a conversation so you don't freeze. Turning something dense into plain English. Explaining an option you'd been too embarrassed to ask about.

What it is not for: the decision itself.

A worked example. You get a letter from an insurer denying a claim. Excellent use: *Explain what this letter is actually saying, and what my options appear to be.* Then: *What should I ask when I ring them?* Bad use: deciding whether to accept the denial based on what it told you, without speaking to anyone.

The pattern is the same in all four: **use it to walk in prepared, not to decide alone.**

Try this now. Think of a letter or appointment you've been avoiding. Use it to write down the three questions you'd want to ask.

08

Scams that use this, and how not to be the mark

The uncomfortable lesson, and the one nobody else's beginner guide includes. This technology is also available to people running scams, and it has removed the tells you were taught to look for.

The bad-grammar tell is dead. A scam email or text can now be fluent, correctly spelled, and written in convincing business English. "It looked professional" is no longer evidence of anything.

Voices can be copied. A short clip of someone speaking — from a video, a voicemail, anywhere public — is enough to make a convincing imitation of them on a phone call.

That second one powers the scam aimed squarely at parents and grandparents:

> A phone call. It's your grandchild's voice. They're in trouble — an accident, an arrest, stranded somewhere. They're upset. They need money now, and please don't tell their parents.

The voice may be genuinely convincing. The urgency and the secrecy are the point: both exist to stop you checking.

THE DEFENCE, AND IT IS COMPLETELY RELIABLE

Hang up and call them back on the number you already have for them. Not a number the caller gives you. If it was really them, you'll reach them. If it wasn't, you've lost nothing.

Three more habits worth having:

Agree a family word. A single word only your family knows, for exactly this call. Ordinary and memorable. Anyone who can't produce it isn't who they say they are.

Treat urgency as the warning sign. Real emergencies survive a five-minute pause and a call back. Manufactured ones can't afford one. *Act now, don't tell anyone, stay on the line* is the shape of a scam regardless of the story.

Verify through a second channel. An email from your bank, a text about a delivery, a message from a friend asking for money — reach them a different way. Ring the number on your card, not the one in the message.

Try this now. Pick your family word. Tell the people who'd need it. That is the highest-value five minutes in this book.

09

A sane way to use it

Pulling all of it into one posture you can actually hold in your head.

Use it freely for: drafting anything, understanding anything, explaining, summarising, brainstorming, practising a difficult conversation, turning mess into order. In this territory the worst case is a bad draft, and you'll notice.

Use it carefully for: anything you're about to send, publish, sign, pay, or act on. Same tool, one extra step — the three-question check from Lesson 6.

Don't use it to decide money, legal, health, or anything irreversible. Use it to understand and prepare, then take the decision to a person.

Don't put in passwords, card numbers, government identification, or other people's private details.

That's the entire book in five lines. Everything else was explaining why.

THE ATTITUDE THAT WORKS BEST

Not suspicion, and not blind trust. Something closer to how you'd treat a clever, well-read, extremely fast colleague who is occasionally and confidently wrong, and who has never met you. You'd use their work. You'd also check it before your name went on it.

The Double-Check Card

Keep this page. It's the whole book at a glance.

Before you act on anything: Could I check this in one search? · Does it matter if it's wrong? · Would I want a person to confirm it?

Always confirm with a person: Money. Legal. Health. Anything you can't undo.

Never type in: Passwords · Card and account numbers · Government ID numbers · Other people's private details.

It cannot see: your email, files, photos, location, or anything else — unless you attach it or connect it yourself.

On the phone, if someone urgently needs money: hang up and call back on the number you already have. Use your family word.

The rule that survives everything: don't type what you'd mind a stranger reading.

When it goes wrong

"I typed something I shouldn't have." Delete that conversation. If it was a password, change the password. That's the whole remedy — the same as typing it into any wrong box.

"It told me something that turned out to be false." Expected, occasionally. Ask what else in that answer it's unsure about, and apply the three-question check. If it happened on something that mattered, that's a signal to check earlier next time, not to stop using it.

"I can't tell whether a message I received is a scam." Reach the sender through a channel you already had — a number on your card, an app you already use. Never through the message itself. You can also paste the message in and ask what's suspicious about it; it's good at spotting the patterns.

"It refused to help with something reasonable." Reword it and say what you need it for. Some refusals are the system being over-cautious. If it still won't, that's a boundary rather than a fault — move on.

"I don't trust it and I can't say why." Reasonable, and worth respecting. Try using it for a week only on things where being wrong costs nothing — drafts, explanations, ideas. Trust built from evidence is sturdier than trust taken on advice, including this book's.

THE GENERAL SHAPE

Almost every problem here is answered by one of three moves: delete it, check it through a second source, or slow down. None of them require understanding how any of this works.

Current as of Q3 2026

The only page tied to things that change. Check you have the current edition.

Where the privacy settings live. In your account settings, under a heading about data or privacy. Look for anything about whether your conversations are used to improve the system, and decide deliberately rather than accepting the default.

Where the policy lives. The privacy policy on the official site. It is the authority on the four questions in Lesson 3 — not this guide, and not anything written about it elsewhere.

Plans differ. Free, paid personal, and business plans can carry different terms. If you move between them, check again.

VERIFY BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

Privacy terms, settings and plan names change, and this page will age faster than the rest of the book. Check the official source rather than trusting a printed page — including this one.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the rest.

Before you act on anything that matters, ask yourself: would I want a person to confirm this?

That single question covers nearly everything in this book. It catches the confident-sounding error. It catches the medical or legal or financial decision that shouldn't be made alone. It even catches the scam phone call, because the answer there is always yes — and the person to confirm with is the one you're already worried about, on a number you already have.

You can forget the other eight lessons. Keep that one.

Do this next

New to this entirely? → Claude for Absolute Beginners — the account, the screen, and the handful of habits that make it work. Read that one first if you haven't set anything up.

Want ideas rather than instruction? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude — ten chapters, every one a complete sentence you can type as-is.

Want better answers first time? → Asking Better Questions — the habits that turn a generic answer into a useful one.

Haven't got the free starter? → Your First Ten Minutes With Claude — six pages, free, one result you'd show someone.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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